

Apply to be a Science Corps Fellow - Entry #3377

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Male
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Chicago, IL, USA
Nationality
USA
When did you or do you expect to complete your PhD?
August 2025
Please tell us briefly about your university education (institution, city, country, year)
I did my undergrad in physics at Harvard from 2016 to 2019. I was a PhD student in the physics department at Stanford from 2019 to 2025. As a PhD student I did research on the evolution of microbial communities. What are the various evolutionary forces that give rise to observed patterns of diversity in natural microbial populations, and can we quantitatively understand these patterns through the lens of simple mathematical models?
Why would you like to be a Science Corps Fellow?
Throughout my PhD I have had a desire to engage with the broader community and ecosystem of science education, in addition to pursuing the research that has formed the bulk of my time in grad school. Part of being a well-rounded scientist is having a vision of where and how science fits into society: such a vision shapes and informs why it is that we do science in the first place. I believe the Science Corps fellowship would allow me to explore aspects of science that I have so far had less experience with, like developing curriculum and strategies for engaging students in under-resourced countries.
I am particularly keen to have such an experience abroad because of the increasing role that other countries (aside from the US) will play in the future of science. As science in the US faces a period of heightened uncertainty due to hostility from the government, it is even more important that the international scientific community is strengthened. I believe that the Science Corps fellowship would allow me to feed a longstanding passion that I have for science education, while also exposing me to a life abroad, and allowing me to contribute to the system of science education that has been such a powerful force in my own life.

Although I have grown up and been educated in the US, I have visited and continue to visit India on a near-yearly basis. These visits have had a large effect on my view of the world and what problems are faced by developing societies, where a larger fraction of the population has to worry about their daily needs being met than in the US. Being a Science Corps fellow would allow me to work in education in a developing country. I am eager to leverage skills from my PhD to contribute to---and learn about---what the issues are with science education around the world.

In addition to your studies, please describe any prior experience that may help you as a Science Corps Fellow.

For a number of years I have had an interest in science education and outreach. As an undergrad I was a staff volunteer in an afterschool program for elementary schoolers in Boston, doing homework and reading and hands-on science activities with the students. For the last six years in graduate school I have been a regular volunteer and co-president of Stanford Science Bus, an organization that does hands-on science experiments and activities with 3rd and 4th graders in East Palo Alto, a 20 minute drive from Stanford. My role in the organization has been to plan and coordinate activities for the students, and organize and recruit volunteers from Stanford. Activities have ranged from engineering challenges involving raw spaghetti and marshmallows to chemical reactions such as the "iodine clock." It has been very rewarding to see the same group of students repeatedly and to get to know their personalities and how they relate to science and to each other. These experiences have taught me how to encourage and build curiosity, and how to relate to younger kids through the medium of science. I have learned that asking questions of students can be an effective way to get them to ask their own questions, which ultimately drives their learning through their own curiosity.

I have also been a teaching assistant for various classes as both an undergrad and graduate student. Some classes have been larger undergrad classes, which have given me experience with engaging with a diverse student body with varying levels of comfort with the subject material. It has been very rewarding to work with the same group of students week after week, and to see them understand concepts that they once struggled with. As a teaching assistant for grad classes, I have gotten a better idea of what sorts of concepts students use the most in upper-level classes, which I believe should influence how we educate students in more introductory classes. I think this broader view of science curriculum is needed in order to build in students a coherent understanding of science across subfields. Such an understanding equips students to appreciate and leverage the power of scientific thinking in their lives, whether or not they become scientists by profession.

Where do you imagine yourself professionally in the future? Check all that apply.

Scientist in academia

In science education

In science outreach

Please expand on your selection above and describe where you imagine yourself professionally in the near (~2 year) and long-term (~10 year) future.

I am currently starting a postdoc at UChicago: the Science Corps fellowship would allow me to interleave this postdoc with an experience that I believe would broaden my perspective as a scientist and an educator. In the future, I am considering a number of options: the academic career path (involving applying for faculty jobs) seems possible, as does something more nonprofit-oriented, like getting more deeply involved in education-based social

work. I believe the Science Corps fellowship could help me to determine what direction I want to go in professionally. Regardless, I know that I want to continue to do science, both as a researcher and as an educator. The exact balance between these aspects that I would like to strike is as yet unclear, but is something that I hope to better understand through this fellowship.

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Please upload your CV (.pdf) [cv.pdf](#)**How did you find out about Science Corps?**

Referred by a friend/colleague/supervisor in academia

[Science Corps](#)